Seam finishing without an overlocker

A companion to Pattern Drafter. Scan a QR code with your phone camera to watch that technique on video.

Which finish goes where

SEAM	FINISH
Shirt	
Yoke to back, yoke to fronts	Burrito yoke
Sleeve to armhole	Flat-felled (sew the sleeve in flat, before closing the side seam)
Side + underarm (one continuous seam)	Flat-felled or French
Front facing edge	Turn-and-stitch
Collar, stand, cuffs	Enclosed by construction, nothing needed
Hem, short sleeve hems	Narrow double-fold hem
Sleeveless armholes	Bias strip turned to the inside and topstitched
Jacket	
Side, sleeve and shoulder seams	Flat-felled (or bias binding on thick canvas)
Hems and sleeve hems	Double-fold (1 + 3 cm)
Trousers & shorts	
Side seams, inside leg	French (light fabric) or flat-felled (sturdy)
Crotch seam (front + back)	Reinforced curved seam
Pocket bags	French seam
Fly facing (fitted)	Turn-and-stitch or bias binding
Leg hems	Double-fold hem

Before you start

- Set **seam allowance to 1.5 cm** in the drafter. French and flat-felled seams need the extra width.
- Press every step. Pressing does half the work of a neat finish.
- Test each finish on scraps of your real fabric first.
- Linen and loose cotton weaves fray fast. Finish each seam right after sewing it.

How to read the drawings: you're looking down at the fabric on your table. Right side Wrong side

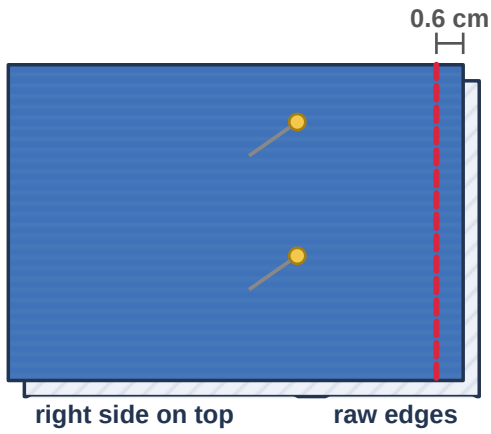
Stitching Fold Hidden underneath Cut away

French seam

Light fabrics: shirt side and sleeve seams, trouser side and inside-leg seams, pocket bags. Needs 1.5 cm seam allowance.

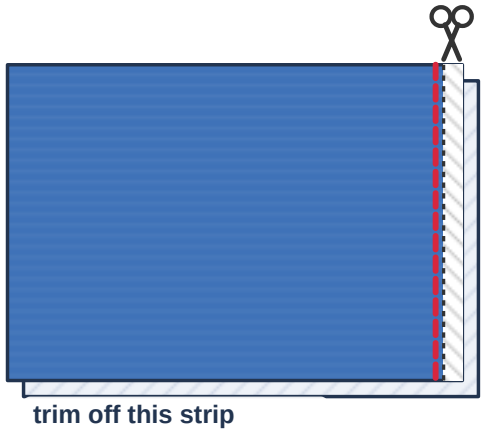
Watch it
Simplicity: French seam (4:36)

1



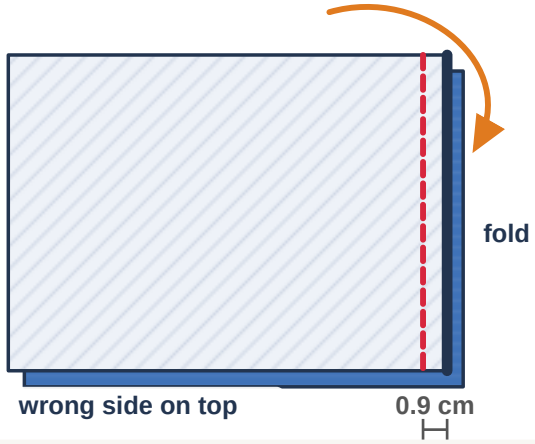
Pin the two pieces **wrong sides together**, so you see the right side on top. Stitch 0.6 cm from the raw edge.

2



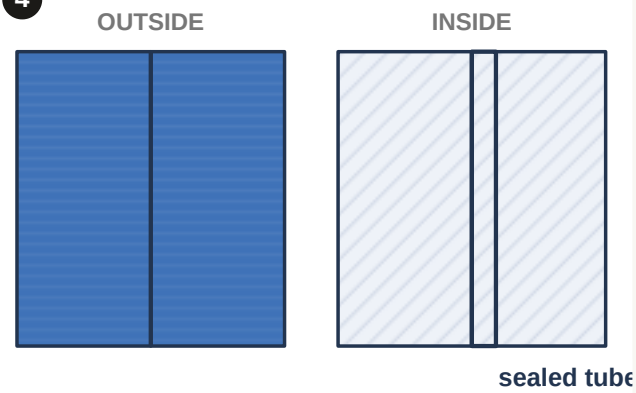
Trim the seam allowance down to 0.3 cm, close to the stitching. Then press the seam flat.

3



Fold the fabric back on itself so the **right sides now face each other**. Roll the seam to sit exactly on the fold and press. Stitch 0.9 cm from the fold.

4



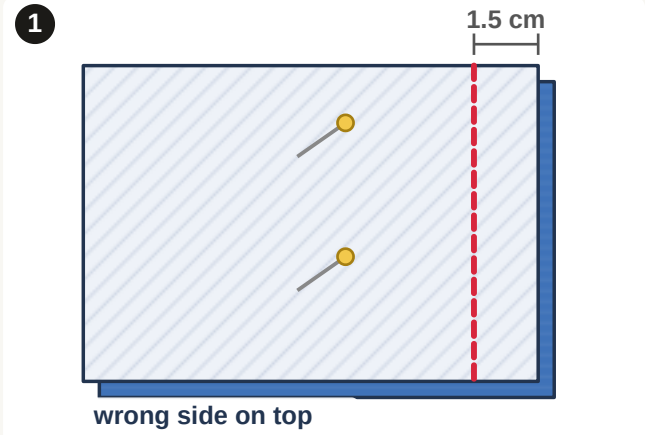
Done. From the outside it's a single neat seam. Inside, the raw edges are sealed in a narrow tube. Press it to one side.

Flat-felled seam

The strongest and cleanest seam. Use it for shirt side seams, sleeves, armholes, jacket seams and sturdy trousers. Needs 1.5 cm seam allowance.

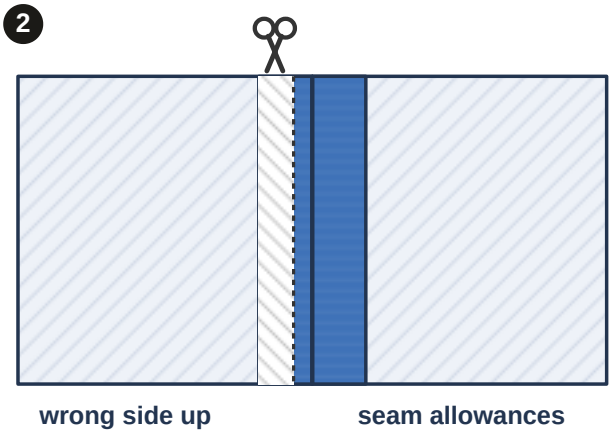
Watch it
Simplicity: Flat felled seams (3:09)

1



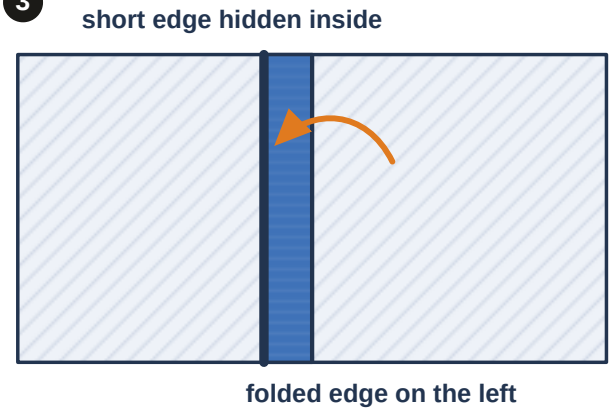
Pin the pieces **right sides together** (you see the wrong side on top). Stitch 1.5 cm from the edge.

2



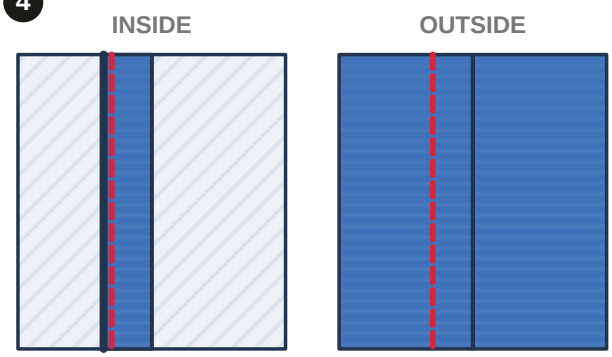
Open the pieces out, wrong side up. The two allowances lie open on either side of the seam. Trim the **left** one down to 0.5 cm.

3



Press both allowances to the left. The wide one covers the trimmed one. Fold the wide one's raw edge under so it wraps around the short one, and press.

4



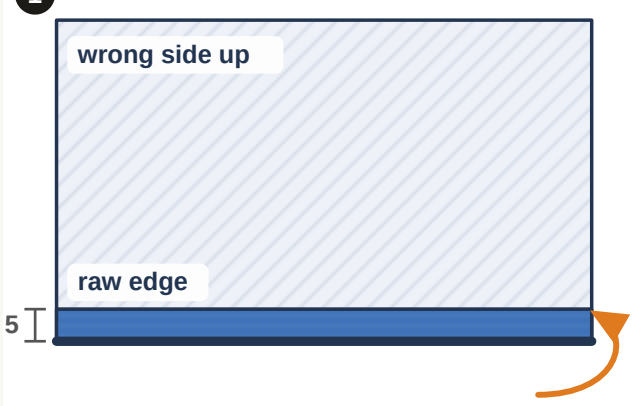
Topstitch close to the folded edge, through all layers. Outside you'll see two neat rows of stitching and no raw edges anywhere.

Narrow double-fold hem

Shirt hems including the curved shirttail, sleeve hems, shorts and trouser hems.

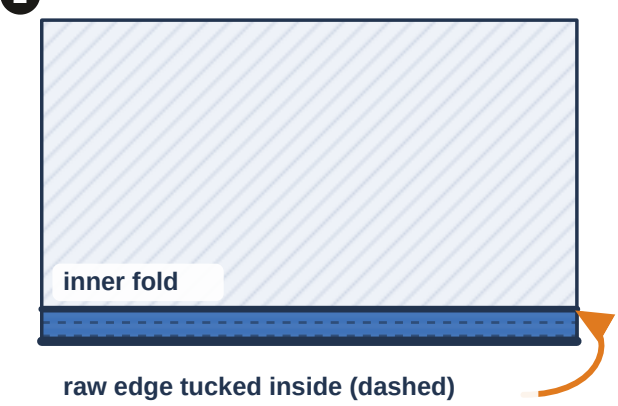
Watch it
Sew Direct: Narrow hems, incl. curved hem

1



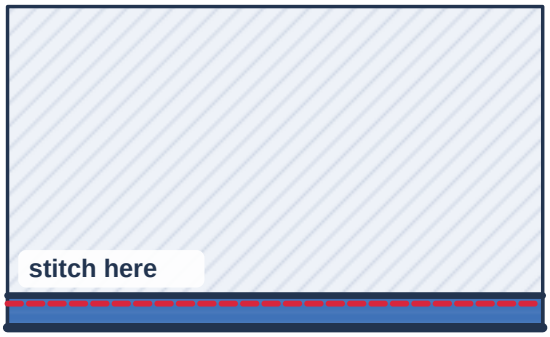
Lay the garment wrong side up. Fold the raw edge up 0.5 cm (1 cm for trousers and shorts) and press.

2



Fold it up again by the same amount, so the raw edge is hidden inside. Press well.

3



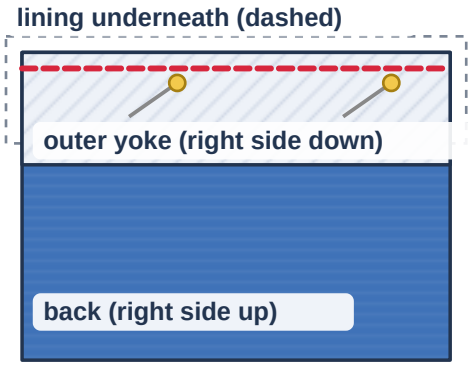
Stitch close to the inner fold. On a curved shirttail, go slowly and ease the fold round with your fingers. Don't stretch the edge.

Burrito yoke

Hides every raw edge on the shirt yoke. You need two yoke pieces: the outer yoke and the lining.

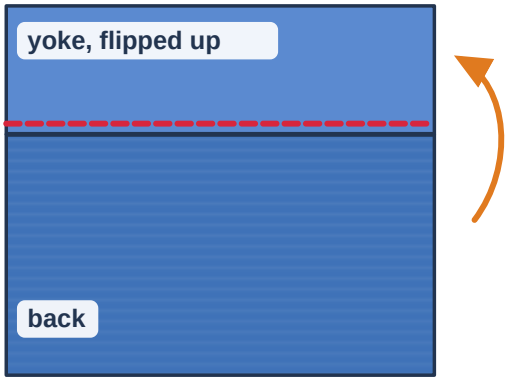
Watch it
Simplicity: Shirt yoke with clean finish (5:05)

1



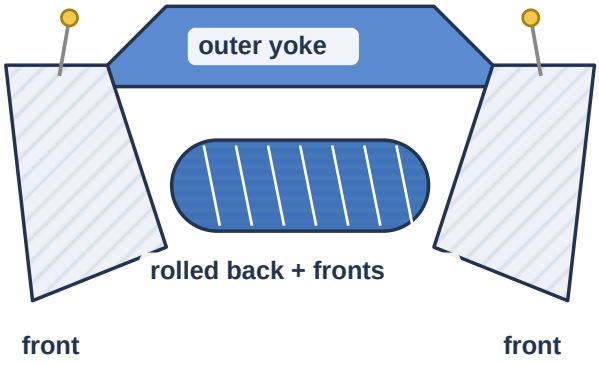
Lay the back right side up. Put the outer yoke on top, right side **down**, edges lined up. Put the yoke lining underneath the back, right side up. Stitch through all three layers.

2



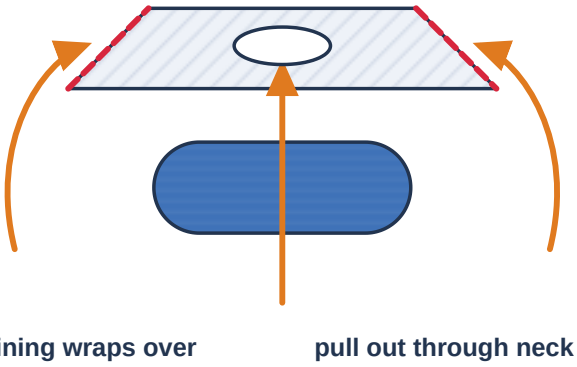
Flip both yoke layers up and press. The back is now sandwiched between them, so the seam is hidden. Topstitch along the yoke.

3



Shoulders: pin the fronts' shoulders to the **outer** yoke, right sides together. Now roll the back and both fronts up tightly towards the yoke. This roll is the burrito filling.

4

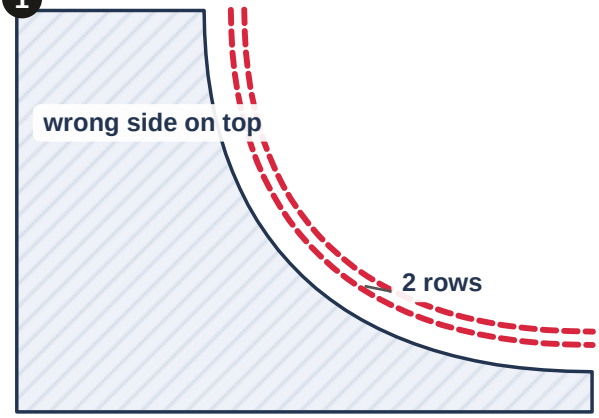


Bring the yoke **lining** over the roll and pin it to the same shoulders, sandwiching the fronts. Stitch both shoulders, then pull the whole shirt out through the neck opening.

Reinforced curved seam

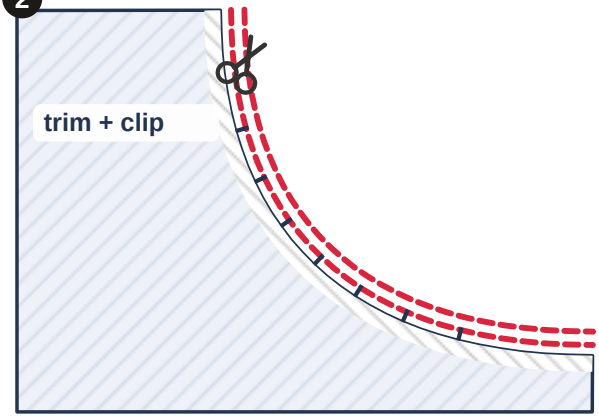
Trouser and shorts crotch seams, and any tight curve where an enclosed seam would pucker.

1



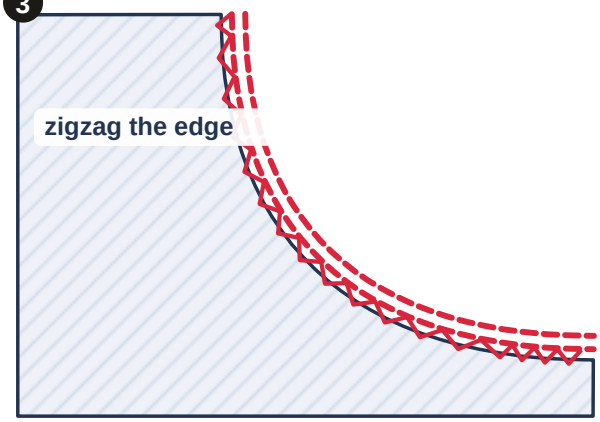
Stitch the curved seam (crotch or armhole) right sides together at 1.5 cm. Then stitch a second row 0.5 cm away, inside the allowance.

2



Trim the allowance to 0.6 cm. On the tightest part of the curve, snip small clips into it every 2 cm. Stop just short of the stitching.

3

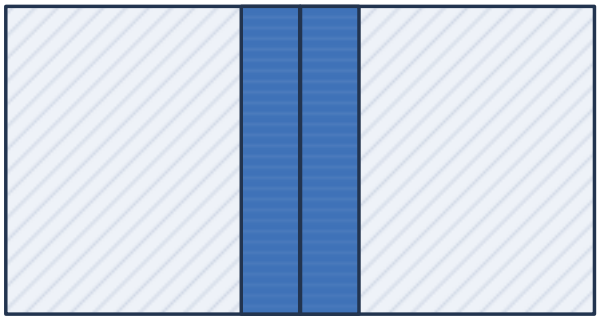


Zigzag over the raw edge so it can't fray (or trim it with pinking shears). Press the seam to one side.

Turn-and-stitch

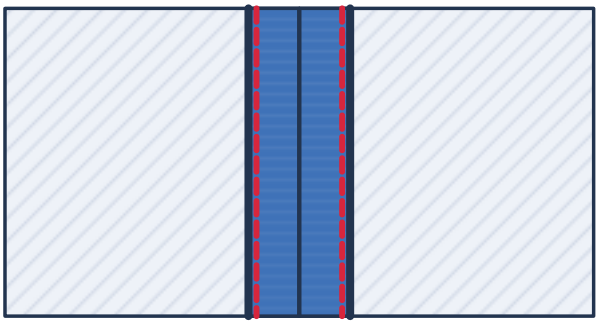
For any open seam in light to medium fabric. It's also how to finish the shirt's front facing edge.

1



Sew the seam as normal and press it open, wrong side up. You'll see the two allowances lying flat either side of the seam.

2



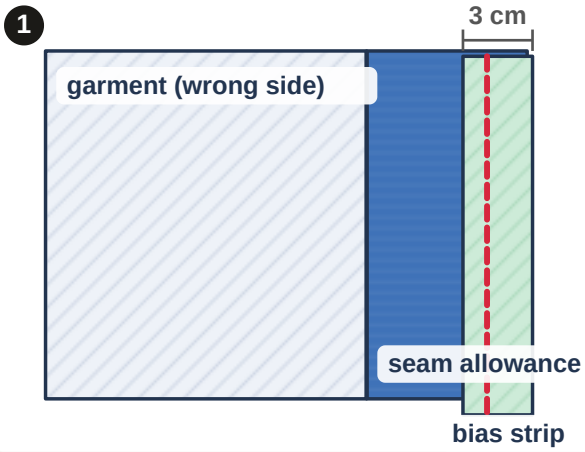
Fold each raw edge under by 0.3 cm and stitch along the fold. Stitch through the allowance only, not through the garment.

Bias binding

For thick fabric (denim, canvas, heavy linen) where folding the edge would be too bulky.

Watch it
Simplicity: Hong Kong seam (4:25)

1



Cut 3 cm strips across the fabric at 45° (the bias, which bends round curves). Lay one on the seam allowance, right sides together, and stitch 0.6 cm in.

2



Wrap the strip round the raw edge to the back, then stitch from the front right in the groove of the first seam to catch it. Called 'stitching in the ditch'.